

Game Theory and Social Choice

Lecture 3: Static Games

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Normal-Form Games

We're going to start with games that have a distinctive structure.

- Each player only moves once.
- These moves are made **simultaneously**.

Examples of this kind of game:

- Rock, Paper, Scissors
- Chess between computer programs

Those two examples have two things in common that we'll want to eventually drop.

- They are **two-player games**.
- They are **zero-sum**.
- Each player has (more or less) **the same options**

The games we're looking at need not have any of these features.

That said, we will spend a fair bit of time with symmetric two player games.

The simplest way to represent a game is with a **payoff matrix**.

This is sometimes called the **normal form** of the game, and sometimes called the **strategic form**.

Table 1: The Prisoner's Dilemma

	C	D
C	3, 3	0, 5
D	5, 0	1, 1

- The rows tell us which options player 1 has.
- The columns tell us which options player 2 has.
- We'll often call these players **Row** (or just **R**) and **Column** (or just **C**).
- Each cell has two numbers: First **Player 1's payoff**, then **Player 2's payoff**.

	C	D
C	3, 3	0, 5
D	5, 0	1, 1

If Player 1 picks C and Player 2 picks D:

- Player 1 gets 0
- Player 2 gets 5

Higher numbers are better, by the lights of that player.

These could be something material (e.g., money, years of freedom), or anything the player values (loyalty, equality, etc.)

If we have three players, the usual approach is to have a set of tables, one for each move player 3 could have.

Table 2: P3 does C

	C	D
C	6, 6, 6	3, 7, 3
D	7, 3, 3	4, 4, 0

Table 3: P3 does D

	C	D
C	3, 3, 7	0, 4, 4
D	4, 0, 4	1, 1, 1

We can't do three dimensions on slides, so we have one table for if P3 plays C, and another table for if they play D.

Formally, we define a game by setting three parameters.

1. The number of **Players**.
2. Which **Actions** are available for each player, remembering that this may be different for different players.
3. The **Payoffs** to each player, for each possible combination of actions.

The payoff matrix captures all three at once.

Classic Games

The Prisoner's Dilemma

Two suspects are arrested and interrogated separately.

- If both **cooperate** (stay silent): light sentence for each.
- If both **defect** (confess): moderate sentence for each.
- If one defects and the other cooperates: the defector goes free, the cooperator gets a harsh sentence.

	Cooperate	Defect
Cooperate	3, 3	0, 5
Defect	5, 0	1, 1

What Should You Do?

	Cooperate	Defect
Cooperate	3, 3	0, 5
Defect	5, 0	1, 1

Consider the game from Player 1's perspective.

- If Player 2 cooperates: I get 3 by cooperating, **5 by defecting**.
- If Player 2 defects: I get 0 by cooperating, **1 by defecting**.

No matter what Player 2 does, defecting is better for me. The same logic applies to Player 2. So both defect, even though both cooperating would be better for everyone.

This is why it's called a *dilemma*:

- Individual rationality leads to (Defect, Defect) with payoffs (1, 1).
- But (Cooperate, Cooperate) with payoffs (3, 3) is better for *both* players.

This tension between individual and collective rationality is one of the deepest problems in social philosophy.

Not all games involve conflict. Sometimes the challenge is just to **coordinate**.

Table 4: Which side of the road?

	Left	Right
Left	1, 1	0, 0
Right	0, 0	1, 1

Neither player wants to mismatch. They just need to pick the same side. This is a **pure coordination game**: both players always get the same payoff.

What if you want to coordinate, but you *disagree about where*?

Table 5: Bach-Stravinsky

	Bach	Stravinsky
Bach	2, 1	0, 0
Stravinsky	0, 0	1, 2

- Both prefer going to the same concert to going to different concerts.
- But Player 1 prefers Bach, and Player 2 prefers Stravinsky.
- This has elements of both **coordination** and **competition**

The older versions of this game have the players be a heterosexual couple with cliched interests.

- Option **B** is the stereotypical male option, pro wrestling or something.
- Option **S** is the stereotypical female option; I'll let you guess one.
- Under this description it was called **Battle of the Sexes**.
- This more modern name keeps the initials, and the payoff table, but changes the backstory.

There's a game that *looks* like the Prisoner's Dilemma but works very differently.

Table 6: Stag Hunt

	Cooperate	Defect
Cooperate	5, 5	0, 3
Defect	3, 0	3, 3

Two hunters can hunt a stag together (big payoff) or each hunt a hare alone (small but guaranteed payoff). Hunting stag only works if *both* commit to it.

In **Prisoner's Dilemma**, defecting is always better for you, regardless of what the other player does.

In **Stag Hunt**, we have ultimately a coordination game; it's best to do what the other person does.

So why is it hard? Don't we just coordinate on the higher payoff option?

What makes Stag Hunt interesting is that doing the pro-social act is **risky**; if it's 50/50 what the other person will do, it's best to take the individualist option.

Dominant Strategies

What's a Dominated Strategy?

A strategy is **strictly dominated** if there's another strategy that is *always* better than it.

A strategy is **weakly dominated** if there's another strategy that is *always* at least as good as it, and *sometimes* better.

Here are two plausible rules (the first, as we'll see, is arguably more plausible):

1. Don't play strictly dominated strategies!
2. Don't play weakly dominated strategies!

We'll focus for now on strict dominance, and come back to weak dominance in a bit, because it's confusing in various ways.

Iterated Elimination of Strictly Dominated Strategies

Consider this game:

Table 7: Iterated dominance example

	L	R
U	1, 1	0, 0
D	0, 3	1, 2

- No option is dominated for Row.
- But for Column, they get more playing **L** than **R** no matter what; **L** strictly dominates **R**.
- And if we know that Column will not play **R**, then on all *remaining* strategies for Column, it's best for Row to choose **U**.

The thought here is that we can sometimes get to a solution of a game by going through and eliminating dominated strategies.

- Because dominance is defined in terms of quantification over remaining strategies, this elimination can make more strategies dominated.
- Repeating (or *iterating*) this process sometimes leads to a unique solution.

Iterated Elimination Example: Ice Cream Trucks

Two trucks each choose a spot (1–5) on a beach with 10 customers at each spot.

- Customers go to the nearest truck; ties split evenly

	1	2	3	4	5
1	25, 25	10, 40	15, 35	20, 30	25, 25
2	40, 10	25, 25	20, 30	25, 25	30, 20
3	35, 15	30, 20	25, 25	30, 20	35, 15
4	30, 20	25, 25	20, 30	25, 25	40, 10
5	25, 25	20, 30	15, 35	10, 40	25, 25

Step 1: Is spot 1 ever a good choice?

Compare spot 1 vs. spot 2 for Truck 1: no matter where the other truck parks, spot 2 always gets more customers.

Spot 1 is **dominated** by spot 2. By symmetry, spot 5 is dominated by spot 4. Eliminate both spots, for both players.

After removing spots 1 and 5:

	2	3	4
2	25, 25	20, 30	25, 25
3	30, 20	25, 25	30, 20
4	25, 25	20, 30	25, 25

Step 2: Now spot 2 is dominated by spot 3 (and spot 4 by spot 3). Again, eliminate both spots for both players.

This game has a unique solution. Both trucks park at **spot 3**.

3	
3	25, 25

Table 8: P3 plays F

	L	R
U	2, 3, 3	3, 2, 2
D	5, 1, 4	0, 0, 1

Table 9: P3 plays B

	L	R
U	1, 0, 1	4, 3, 1
D	4, 0, 2	1, 3, 0

This can be solved by first deleting **B** (for back) for P3, then deleting **R** for P2, then deleting **U** for P1. (It's worth verifying all these steps!)

We'll introduce the main solution concept for games that can't be solved by this iterated deletion: **Nash Equilibrium**.

Then we'll come back to the concept of weak domination, and how it introduces various complications.